

Catholic composer

Around this time, he converted to Catholicism and, taking advantage of the queen's endorsement, composed music for the Catholic services as well as for the Anglican Church. But in the 1580s, attitudes toward Catholics began to harden, and he and his family were under suspicion because of their connections with prominent Catholic families. Despite repeated accusations of recusancy—refusing to attend Anglican services—Byrd continued to compose for both the Church of England and the Catholic rites, but rather cynically curried favor with the Protestant nobility by dedicating many of his compositions to them. These included, as well as the two collections of motets, known as *Cantiones sacrae*, a large number of pieces for instrumental consorts, two English song-books, and *My Lady Nevells Booke* for keyboard—all of which were written with the popular market in mind.

Byrd remarried after his wife's death, and in 1593 or 1594 moved with his family to Stondon Massey in Essex, where he had Catholic friends, including his patron, Sir John Petre. This gave him the opportunity to compose the cycles of Catholic Masses for three, four, and five voices, and the two sets of motets, the *Gradualia*. These were his last major works before his retirement.